1984 by George Orwell

By Greg Nagan

NARRATOR: **(Pg 171)** In 1949, when George Orwell wrote his infamous novel 1984, most of Western Civilization was struggling against totalitarianism – the political theory that the state should have **total** control over **every** citizen. Orwell set out to show that the tyrannical subjugation of the masses by torture and brainwashing was, indeed, a bad idea.

INTRODUCTION

Today we are seeing new limits on the rights and privileges of Americans. Gun control, abortion, LGBTQ rights, book banning, free and fair elections, immigration and asylum. The list of political battleground issues continues to grow.

A few years ago, no one would have believed that the government had the power to close businesses and schools for over a year because of COVID-19; but it happened. The country came to a standstill because "Big Brother" was the only one who was wise enough to protect us from ourselves. Right?

1984 by George Orwell as reimagined by Greg Nagan

NARRATOR: **(Pg 171-173)** It was a bright cold day in April, and the clocks were striking thirteen: it was the future, and everything sucked. Winston Smith hurried upstairs to his apartment. In the hallway he passed a big poster of a handsome man whose eyes appears to be following you. (They used to have those jiggly eyes – those had been fun – but the Party had eventually settled on an iron-clad policy of NO FUN) Below were the words BIG BROTHER IS WATCHING YOU. This was also a recent innovation, ten years ago [it] replaced the original slogan, YOU'RE UNDER CONSTANT SURVEILLANCE, MAGGOT.

Winston let himself into his room and looked out the window at the Party ministries with rose imposingly above the city: The Ministry of Peace, which dealt with war; the Ministry of Love, which dealt with punishment; the Ministry of Truth, which dealt with propaganda; and the Ministry of Cute Little Puppy Dogs, which dealt with cats.

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Slogans were etched into the windowless sides of the mammoth Ministry of Love: WAR IS PEACE; FREEDOM IS SLAVERY, IGNORANCE IS STRENGTH; BUT DIAMONDS ARE A GIRL'S BEST FIREND.

Winston worked in the Ministry of Truth and Hate Week was not far off. He had come home on his lunch hour to commit an act of enormous defiance – of rebellion. He stepped into an alcove beside the telescreen – it was on, of course – it was impossible to turn off – the alcove was the only part of his cramped and dreary little apartment into which the telescreen could not see.

He withdrew from his desk a diary and fountain pen which he had bought from an illegal diary and fountain pen dealer. Against all laws and regulation, he began to write:

WINSTON: *(speaking as he writes)* ***I hate the future: everything sucks. I hate my job because everything really does suck . . .***

NARRATOR: The worst crime of all was thoughtcrime. It was only a matter of time before he would be caught.

WINSTON: *(speaking as he writes)* ***I'm a doomed man. Doom sucks.***

NARRATOR: The next day at the Ministry of Truth he spent his morning rewriting old newspaper and history books to reflect the truth as adjusted by the Party. That was his job.

WINSTON: It sucks.

NARRATOR: He had lunch with people he didn't like. While they ate . . .

TELESCREEN: The standard of living has risen another 20 percent.

WINSTON: *(Applause)*

TELESCREEN: Another battle has been won against Eurasia.

WINSTON: *(Applause)*

TELESCREEN: Big Brother wants everyone to stand up.

WINSTON: *(Stands up)*

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TELESCREEN: Big Brother wants everyone to sit down.

WINSTON: *(Sits down)*

TELESCREEN: Everyone should stand on one leg.

WINSTON: *(Starts to, then stops)*

NARRATOR: A few people did, and they were taken out and shot because Big Brother hadn't said to.

WINSTON: *(thumbs up to the audience with a big smile and a fake wiping of sweat from his brow)*

NARRATOR: **(Pg 175-177)** One day Winston's section chief approached his cubicle. O'Brien was the Inner Party man Winston suspected of secretly sharing his view that everything sucked.

O'BRIEN: *(in a suspicious manner)* I've been reading your columns . . . Come by my house. *(he hands Winston a piece of paper)* Here's my address. Come by any time. *(he exits)*

WINSTON: *(to audience)* Awfully clever. The Party would suspect nothing.

NARRATOR: And yet it was clear O'Brien was inviting Winston to come by his house and talk privately

WINSTON: About how much everything sucked!

NARRATOR: And maybe, just maybe, he'd invite Winston

WINSTON: To join the Brotherhood! *(awkward non-verbal celebration)*

*******A Few Weeks Later / O'Brien's Study *******

O'BRIEN: Why are you here?

WINSTON: I want to join the Brotherhood and dedicate my life to fighting the Party.

O'BRIEN: I see. Very good. *(Taking out a checklist)* Are you willing to die for the Brotherhood?

WINSTON: Yes.

O'BRIEN: Would you put a kitten into a blender for the Brotherhood?

WINSTON: Yeeessss?

O'BRIEN: *(switching over to a baby voice)* Even if it was an adorable little kitty-cat looking

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at you with those big eyes and going meow, meow and just so cute you could scream?

WINSTON: *(with resolve)* Yes!

O'BRIEN: Really? Wow. That's good to know. Now go home and pretend nothing has happened. You'll never meet any other members; you'll never know that anything's different at all. Some time when you don't expect it a man will hand you a briefcase, and in that briefcase will be a cove of THE BOOK which explains everything. Leave now.

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WINSTON: **(Pg 178)** HATE, HATE, HATE! *(stomping, thrusting his fist in the air)*

NARRATOR: Hate Week came at last and all of Oceania lathered itself into a frenzy chanting hate for all enemies of Big Brother.

WINSTON: HATE, HATE, HATE! *(stomping, thrusting his fist in the air)*

NARRATOR: And then . . . suddenly . . .

WINSTON: *(he notices the large telescreen and makes a mad scramble to grab and place various hats on his head, pushing, shoving invisible others)*

NARRATOR: There was a mad panic; everyone **had** to have a hat and had to have it at once. There was violence, rioting. Apparently, there'd been a typo and the telescreens were suddenly telling everyone to celebrate HAT WEEK. Anyone not wearing a hat was taken out and shot.

STRANGER: *(to Winston, slyly)* I think you dropped your briefcase.

WINSTON: I didn't bring my briefcase.

STRANGER: I think you did.

WINSTON: I'm pretty sure I didn't. *(exasperated, the stranger motions with the briefcase; Winston finally remembers the directive from O'Brien)* Sorry! *(he takes the briefcase)*

NARRATOR: At last he would have a chance to read THE BOOK.

***** **A few days later** *****

WINSTON: **(Pg 179-181)** *(reading aloud)* **THE THEORY AND PRACTICE OF OLIGARCHIC COLLECTIVISM** *(makes exaggerated excited and somewhat scared face)* Chapter One:

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Ignorance is Strength – Since the dawn of man, there have been three varieties of human kind: the idiots, the morons and the bastards. *(reacts to the sentence; flips pages, skimming for the answers he wants)* Perpetual state of warfare . . . easier for the governments to suck and to make life suck for their people . . . everything sucks for everyone forever. *(nods head; book is affirming that he was right)*

NARRATOR: He read how there could never be any more revolutions because there were no longer any unhappy people. At the first signs of unhappiness people were taken out and shot.

WINSTON: That sucks!

NARRATOR: [And] Before he had a chance to . . .

WINSTON: The apartment was invaded by Thought Police! It has all been a setup! *(Winston takes blow after blow from the Thought Police)*

NARRATOR: They beat the crap out of him. Not very futuristic, but effective. [He] woke up in jail. Days went by; weeks, months, maybe even years. Thought Police would come in at erratic intervals and beat him or tickle him until he wet his pants.

O'BRIEN: I'm going to torture you until you realize that Big Brother loves you, and that you love Big Brother.

WINSTON: Big Brother Sucks! *(succumbing to tickle torture with an embarrassed look as he wets himself)*

NARRATOR: He could take no more.

WINSTON: Don't torture me. I don't care, just leave me alone!

O'BRIEN: I was hoping you'd say that. You're free to go.

NARRATOR: **(Pg 182)** A few months later, Winston was sitting alone at a café.

WINSTON: *(with a vacant look on his face attempts to drink from a coffee cup, but spills it down his front; it's clear that the beatings have had an effect on his intellect)*

NARRATOR: Once in a while he'd look up at the poster BIG BROTHER IS WATCHING YOU and feel a certain reassurance. *(Winston looks up and smiles creepily)* It was sort of comforting to be watched. He liked the idea that someone was looking out for him.

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He felt filled with warmth. *(Winston wets his pants, notices, but is not embarrassed, he just smiles)* The future didn't suck after all. He loved Big Brother. Maybe love was too strong a word. But he liked him. He really, really liked him.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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